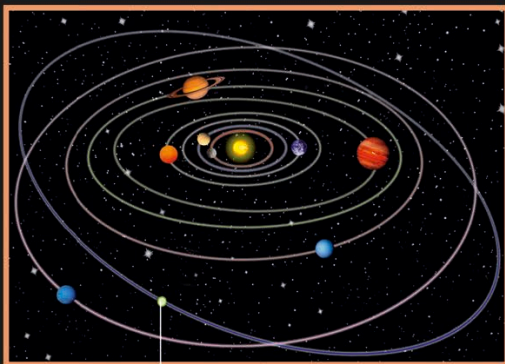
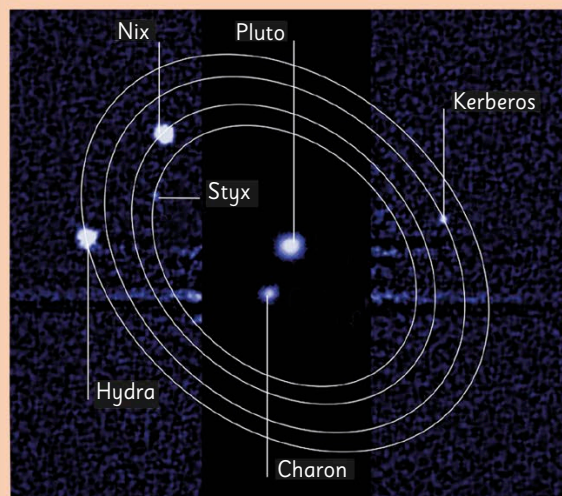


Pluto's orbit

Pluto orbits the Sun slightly differently to the main planets. Its orbit also takes it nearer to the Sun than Neptune for part of the 248 Earth years of its orbit.

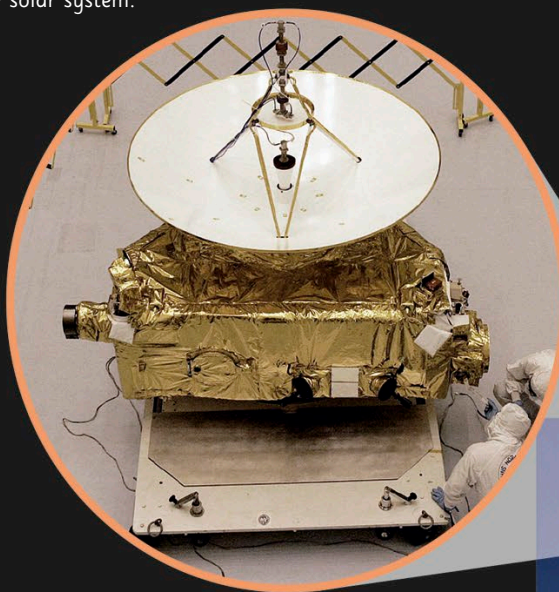


Pluto doesn't lie in the same plane as the eight planets of the solar system.



Pluto has five known moons. The largest is called Charon. It moves around Pluto every six days. Two smaller moons, Nix and Hydra, were discovered in 2005. Kerberos and Styx were discovered in 2011 and 2012, respectively.

Pluto takes 248 Earth years to orbit the Sun. Its surface is thought to be mainly frozen nitrogen, with traces of methane.



New Horizons is one of the fastest spacecraft ever to be launched.

New Horizons blasted into space on board an *Atlas 5* rocket.

A mission to Pluto

In 2006, the US space agency NASA launched a spacecraft called *New Horizons* to study Pluto and other objects in the Kuiper Belt. In 2015, it flew by Pluto and is now headed for an encounter with a Kuiper Belt object in 2019.



Dwarf planets

Just look at this picture comparing the size of Pluto with other dwarf planets. Eris was only discovered in 2005. Ceres is the size of the US state Texas. It lies in the main asteroid belt between Mars and Jupiter, and is the biggest celestial body there.